Yew Piney Mountain

Fiddle Tune • Key of A • Low D Harmonica • 2nd Position • AABB Form

Source: Grant Dermody — Crossing That River

Watch the A Part Lesson

Basic Melody

A Part — Play Twice

```
+6 -6 +6 -5 -4    -5-4-5-4+4-3-3-2
+6 -5 -4 +4 -4 -5 +6

+6 -6 +6 -5 -4    -5-4-5-4+4-3-+4
'-4 '-4  -4 -5 -4 +4 -3 -2

-1 -2 -3 -2 -"2 -1-1 +1   +1-1 +2 +3 -123
```

Repeat

B Part — Play Twice

```
+1/4 -123 +123 +123
-1/4 -dahda -1/4 -Dahda +1/4 -1/4 +1/4 -34 -2 -Dah +1/4 +1/4
-1/4 -dahda  +1/4 -1/4 +1/4 -34 -2

+3 +3 -34 -34 +1/4 +1/4
-1/4 -2/5 -1/4 +1/4 -34 -2

-1 -2 -3 -2 -"2 -1-1 +1   +1-1 +2 +3 -123
```

Repeat

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Watch the A Part Lesson

Origins

Yew Piney Mountain is one of the great old time fiddle tunes from the heart of West Virginia. It's believed to have been composed by Lewis Johnson "Uncle" Jack McElwain, born 1856 in White Oak, Webster County. He was a fiddler so respected in central West Virginia that no one can recall him ever being beaten in a contest. The tune was one of two favourites in central and southern West Virginia, the other being "Jimmy Johnson."

The earliest known recording goes all the way back to 1930, when Jean Thomas recorded fiddler Ed Morrison from Boyd County, Kentucky, for the Library of Congress at the American Folk Song Festival. From there it passed through legendary players. French Carpenter learned it from "old Uncle John Smacawayne" as a boy, and his student Wilson Douglas famously said it took him "five long years" to master it. Ernie Carpenter, Burl Hammons, and Lee Hammons all carried their own versions of this tune forward, keeping it alive in the tradition.

Grant Dermody & Crossing That River

This version comes from Grant Dermody's 2003 album Crossing That River, an album he dedicated to Piedmont blues legend John Jackson. Grant's harmonica playing on that record really showed what this tune could sound like on the harp. He plays harmonica and provides lead vocals on all songs featured on the album. Yew Piney Mountain appears as the final track.

Playing This Tune

This is played in second position on a Low D harmonica in the key of A. The AABB form gives the tune its structure. The A part sits in the upper middle register with a modal, slightly crooked feel that's characteristic of the old West Virginia style. The B part drops down into the low register with octave splits and a driving rhythmic pulse. Pre-requisites: you need to be comfortable with bends and ideally be able to play octave splits. If you're playing this solo, a good rhythmic foundation underneath will hold it together.

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